leadership. The landing zone could accommodate only two helicopters and the ones in the first wave were hit by enemy fire, meaning only one 10 PARA (Cdo) company and one 13 SIKH LI platoon were delivered. Pinned down, the Indian troops tried to break the LTTE cordon, but soon ran out of ammunition. The Sikhs made a bayonet charge but all but one were killed. The commandos lost six of their men, but managed to extricate themselves and moved on to their objective at Kokuvil. Having failed to find the LTTE leaders, the para-commando company was relieved the next morning by their battalion, led by a column of T-72 tanks. The operation ended as an unmitigated disaster for the IPKF.



Paratroopers of the IPKF keep a lookout for Tamil guerrillas from their post in northern Sri Lanka, October 1989. During Operation *Pawan*, most of the Parachute Regiment (five battalions) were to serve in Sri Lanka, with 10 PARA (Cdo) being the first to do so; it arrived in August 1987 and was the divisional reserve unit of 54 Infantry Division. In October 1987, 5 PARA joined the IPKF. The parachute battalions were rotated during the 32-month Indian Army involvement in Sri Lanka and were among the last troops to leave in March 1990. (Robert Nickelsberg/Getty Images)